



# Language Endangerment and Reclamation

Ling 97R Sophomore Tutorial [Spring 2024]

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# Introductions

- name and pronouns
- concentration(s) and year
- house
- languages spoken where you grew up
- what does language mean to you?



**What does it mean to reclaim  
a language and/or culture?  
Why is it important?**

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- who gets to reclaim a language?
  - what counts as an indigenous language and/or culture?
  - is language change and loss natural?
  - what is the role of a linguist and/or outsider?
  - what does decolonization look like?



2022-2032 | INTERNATIONAL DECADE OF  
**Indigenous Languages**



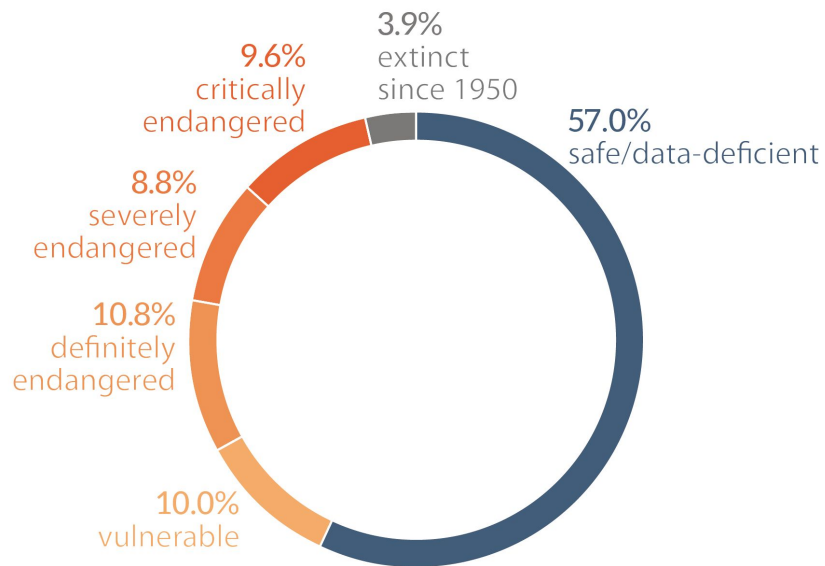
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# Endangerment: history, education, ideology, critiques

Week 2

## Languages of the world today

- ~7,000 languages in the world
- scientists predict 90% of the world's language will become dormant within a century (Bromham et al. 2021)
- the top 10 languages are spoken by ~70% of the world (Ethnologue)



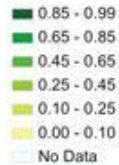
Data source: Federal Union of European Nationalities

EPRS | European Parliamentary Research Service

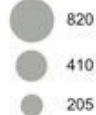
# Linguistic Diversity Around the World

The index of linguistic diversity is a number ranging between zero (0) and one (1) and reflects the amount of linguistic diversity in each country. A linguistically diverse country is characterized by the presence of a number of linguistic groups. In a linguistically homogeneous country a great majority of population speak a single language. In the extreme case of diversity (index = 1), everybody speaks a different language; in the extreme case of homogeneity (index = 0), all people speak one language.

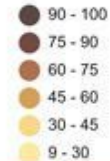
## Index of Linguistic Diversity



## Number of Spoken Languages in Each Country



## Native Languages As Percent of All Spoken Languages

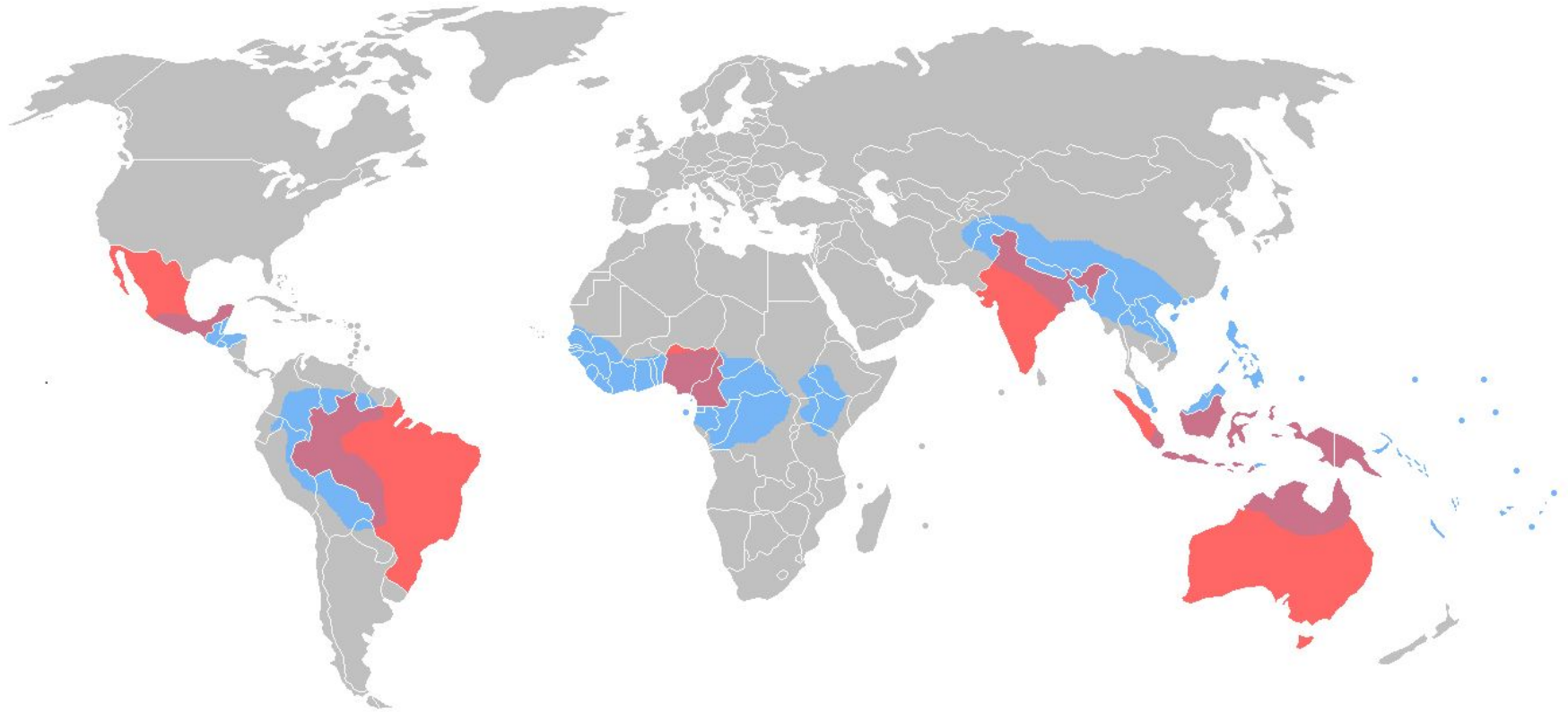


## Countries with the largest number of spoken languages

|                  |     |
|------------------|-----|
| Papua New Guinea | 820 |
| Indonesia        | 742 |
| Nigeria          | 516 |
| India            | 427 |
| United States    | 311 |
| Mexico           | 297 |
| Cameroon         | 280 |
| Australia        | 275 |
| China            | 241 |

## Countries with the highest index of linguistic diversity

|                          |      |
|--------------------------|------|
| Papua New Guinea         | 0.99 |
| Vanuatu                  | 0.97 |
| Tanzania                 | 0.96 |
| Solomon Islands          | 0.96 |
| Central African Republic | 0.96 |
| Chad                     | 0.95 |
| Dem. Rep. of Congo       | 0.95 |
| Cameroon                 | 0.94 |
| India                    | 0.93 |



Wikipedia: 50% of the world's endangered languages are in 8 countries (red)  
coincides with the most linguistically diverse places in the world (blue)

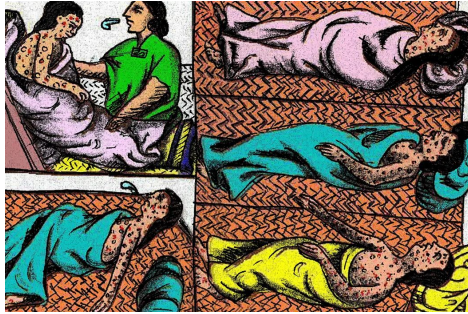
# How did we get here?

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historical and ongoing processes:

- 1) colonization and forced assimilation
- 2) cultural and economic dominance
- 3) lack of educational and linguistic resources
- 4) globalization and urbanization
- 5) political conflict and climate change



# THE OBSERVER

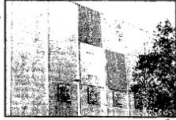
January 29, 1997

THE STUDENT VOICE OF FORDHAM COLLEGE AT LINCOLN CENTER

VOLUME XVI, Issue 9

## Coliseum Proposals Made Public

Photo: Larry Ford



You can't get the seven gods of happiness at this Coliseum.

By Cara Lynn Shultz

## Ebonics Debate Continues

By Chris Maloney

The recent decision of the Oakland, California school board to introduce Black English, or Ebonics,

into the city's public high schools is causing an uproar in major cities across the United States. In New York, educators as well as citizens are voicing their opinions regarding this controversial issue.

Ebonics, the term used to describe a unique form of the African American

languages was never correct nor complete. The use of double negatives is prevalent in African languages, therefore it serves as a basis for the broken English.

Many noted educators nationwide are refusing to acknowledge Black English as a primary language for African American students. Reverend Jesse Jackson criticized the Oakland program on national television as an "unacceptable surrender bordering on

in its care prepare themselves for the larger society," he said in the paper. "But using Black English as a 'teaching tool' will in fact only retard the process." Price added.

Many Fordham students agree. Charles Gray, FCLC '00, said, "I'm totally against Ebonics. I don't feel Ebonics should be instituted into a grade school learning system where the objective is to learn proper grammar."

Sara Levine, FCLC '98, added, "We

## ideologies about language:

- 1) standardization and monolingualism
- 2) nationalism and linguistic purity
- 3) prejudice towards language varieties
- 4) myths about indigenous languages



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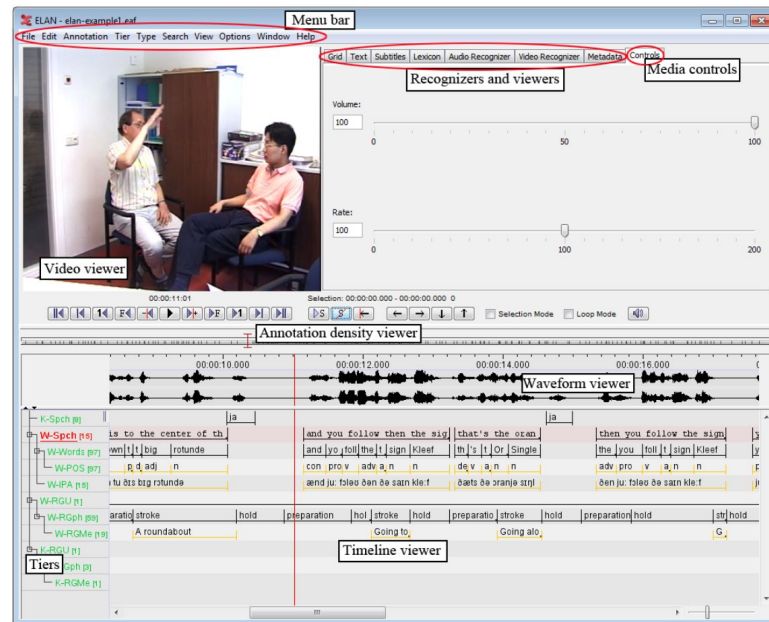
**Methods:**  
**documentation, orthography,**  
**translation, contact, variation**

Week 4



# Documentation

- possible actors/roles in a project
- methods of gathering data
- data organization and processing
- language archives and corpora
- languages resources (dictionaries, grammars, educational materials)





## Practical issues

- orthography → do we use the Roman alphabet?  
what if it doesn't fit the language's sound system?
- translation → how do we teach terms/phrases that aren't translatable?
- contact → do we accept lexical and phonological borrowings?  
how do we deal with contact-induced structural changes?
- variation → what varieties should we teach?  
should there be some form of standardization?

## Massachusett

*Massachusee unnontowaonk*  
*Mâsach8see unôôt8âôk*<sup>[1]</sup>  
 (Muhsachuweesee unôtuwâôk)

/məhsatʃəw[iː]see ənātuwaːāk/<sup>[2]</sup>

*Wôpanâôtuwâôk*  
 /wãpanaːã tuwaːāk/<sup>[3]</sup>

- Native to** [United States](#)
- Region** Eastern [Massachusetts](#), southeastern [New Hampshire](#), and northern and southeastern [Rhode Island](#)<sup>[4][5]</sup>
- Ethnicity** [Massachusett](#), [Wômpañâak](#) (Wampanoag), Pawtucket ([Naumkeag](#), [Agawam](#)), [Nauset](#), and Coweset. Neighboring Algonquian peoples as a second language.<sup>[6]</sup>
- Extinct** Extinct late 19th century (around 1890?)  
<sup>[7][8]</sup>
- Revival** Revitalization from 1993. As of 2014, 5 children are native speakers, 15 are proficient second-language speakers and 500 are adult second-language learners.<sup>[9][10]</sup>

Comparison of Colonial Massachusett and Modern Wôpanâak alphabets

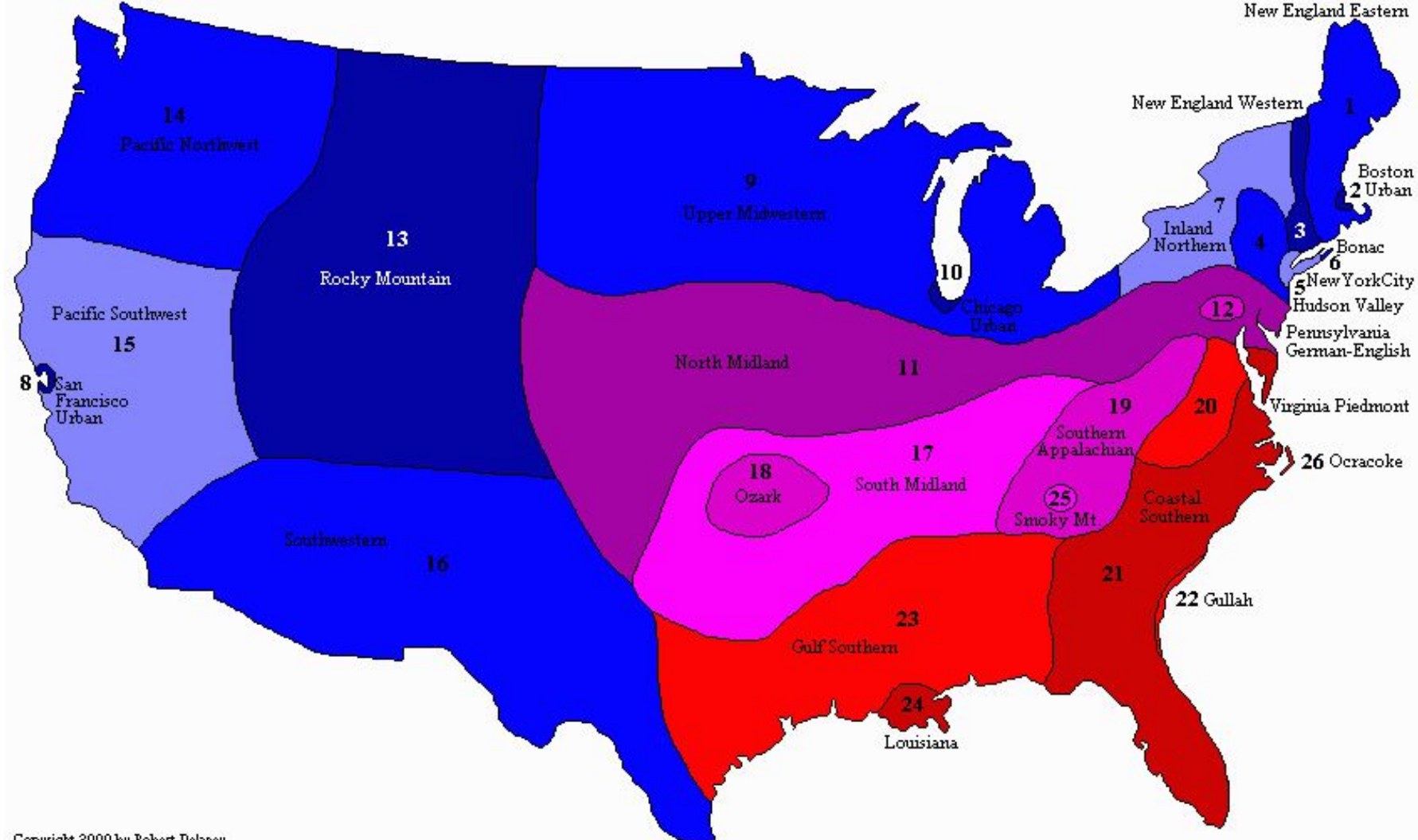
| Colonial |                              |           | Modern |        |      | Colonial    |                       |              | Modern |           |      |
|----------|------------------------------|-----------|--------|--------|------|-------------|-----------------------|--------------|--------|-----------|------|
| Letter   | Values                       | Name      | Letter | Values | Name | Letter      | Values                | Name         | Letter | Values    | Name |
| A a      | /a/, /aː/, /ā/, /ə/          | a         | A a    | /a/    | a    | N n         | /n/, /~ɔ/             | en           | N n    | /n/       | na   |
|          |                              |           | Â â    | /aː/   | â    | O           | /a/, /aː/, /ā/, /ə/   | o            |        |           |      |
| B b      | /b/, /p/                     | bee       |        |        |      |             |                       |              | Ô ô    | /ā/       | ô    |
| C c      | /k/, /s/, /ʃ/                | fee (see) |        |        |      | OO          | /uː/, /wə/, /əw/, /ə/ | co           | Ȳ ȳ    | /uː/      | ȳ    |
| Ch ch    | /tʃ/, /tʃ/, /tʃʰ/            | chee      | Ch ch  | /tʃ/   | cha  | P p         | /p/                   | pee          | P p    | /p/       | pa   |
| D d      | /d/, /t/                     | dee       |        |        |      | Q q         | /kʰ/, /k/             | kéuh         | Q q    | /kʰ/, /k/ | qa   |
| E e      | /i/, /ə/, /ɔ/                | e         | E e    | /ʰə/   | e    | R r         | /r/, /r/              | ar           |        |           |      |
|          |                              |           | Ee ee  | /iː/   | ee   | S s f       | /s/, /ʃ/              | ef (es)      | S s    | /s/       | sa   |
| F f      | /f/, /p/                     | ef        |        |        |      |             |                       |              | Sh sh  | /ʃ/       | sha  |
| G g      | /g/, /k/, /dʒ/, /ʒ/          | gee       |        |        |      | T t         | /t/                   | tee          | T t    | /t/       | ta   |
| H h      | /h/, /ɔ/                     |           | H h    | /h/    | ha   |             |                       |              | Ty ty  | /t/       | tya  |
| I i      | /ə/, /i/, /aɪ/, /aj/         | i         |        |        |      | U u         | /uː/, /a/, /ə/        | u            | U u    | /ə/       | u    |
| J j      | /dʒ/, /ʒ/, /tʃ/, /tʃ/, /tʃʰ/ | ji        |        |        |      | V v         | /v/, /p/              | vf (uf), úph |        |           |      |
| K k      | /k/                          | ka        | K k    | /k/    | ka   | W w         | /w/                   | wee          | W w    | /w/       | wa   |
| L l      | /l/, /n/                     | el        |        |        |      | X           | /ks/, /z/             | eks          |        |           |      |
| M m      | /m/, /~ɔ/[p]/                | em        | M m    | /m/    | ma   | Y y         | /j/, /aj/, /aɪ/, /i/  | wy           | Y y    | /j/       | ya   |
|          |                              |           |        |        |      | Z z         | /z/, /s/              | zad          |        |           |      |
|          |                              |           |        |        |      | Y (P) y (b) | /θ~ð/, /t/            |              |        |           |      |

the Massachusett writing system

| IPA   | English  | Japanese | Korean (MR) | Korean (Han'gŭl) |
|-------|----------|----------|-------------|------------------|
| /ʌ/   | bus      | basu     | pōsŭ        | 버스               |
| /ɜ/   | service  | sābisu   | sōbisŭ      | 서비스              |
| /iə/  | earring  | iyaringu | iōring      | 이어링              |
| /ʊə/  | manicure | manikyua | maenik'yuō  | 매니큐어             |
| /ɛə/  | hair     | hea      | heō         | 헤어               |
| /ɔə/  | door     | doa      | toō         | 도어               |
| /aʊə/ | shower   | shawā    | syawō       | 샤워               |

English loanwords in Japanese and Korean





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# Revitalization: global contexts, models, sustainability

Week 5





↑ Taiwan

Botswana →



← Canada

□ Ecuador



**What counts as success in  
language revitalization?**

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## Education

- community involvement and direction
- linguistic documentation and knowledge
- domains of use: home, classroom, public
- curriculum development and teacher training
- technology and online resources
- institutional support and funding



# Culture

- language is culture, so their reclamation go hand in hand
- incorporate traditional knowledge, including oral and ritual practices
- interdisciplinary approaches: history, art, science, ecology, religion, food, music, dance, architecture, storytelling, fashion, technology, foraging, etc.





# Indigenous languages of North America

- major language families:  
Na-Dene, Algic, Uto-Aztecan
- major languages: Nahuatl,  
Mayan languages, Mixtec,  
Zapotec, Kalaallisut, Navajo,  
Cree, Ojibwe, Inuktitut, etc.
- ~170 languages in the U.S.,  
~ half a million speakers (US Census)
- notable language diversity in  
California, with ~18 families  
and 74 languages spoken



caribou (Mi'kmaq)



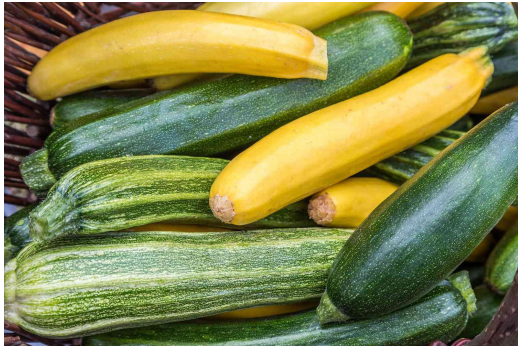
chipmunk (Ojibwe)



husky (Innut)



squash (Massachusetts)



pecan (Illinois)



skunk (Abenaki)



more animal/plant names: moose, muskrat, opossum, raccoon, woodchuck, hickory

Chicago (Miami-Illinois)



Mississippi (Ojibwe)



Michigan (Ojibwe)



tomahawk (Powhatan)



powwow (Narragansett)



totem (Ojibwe)

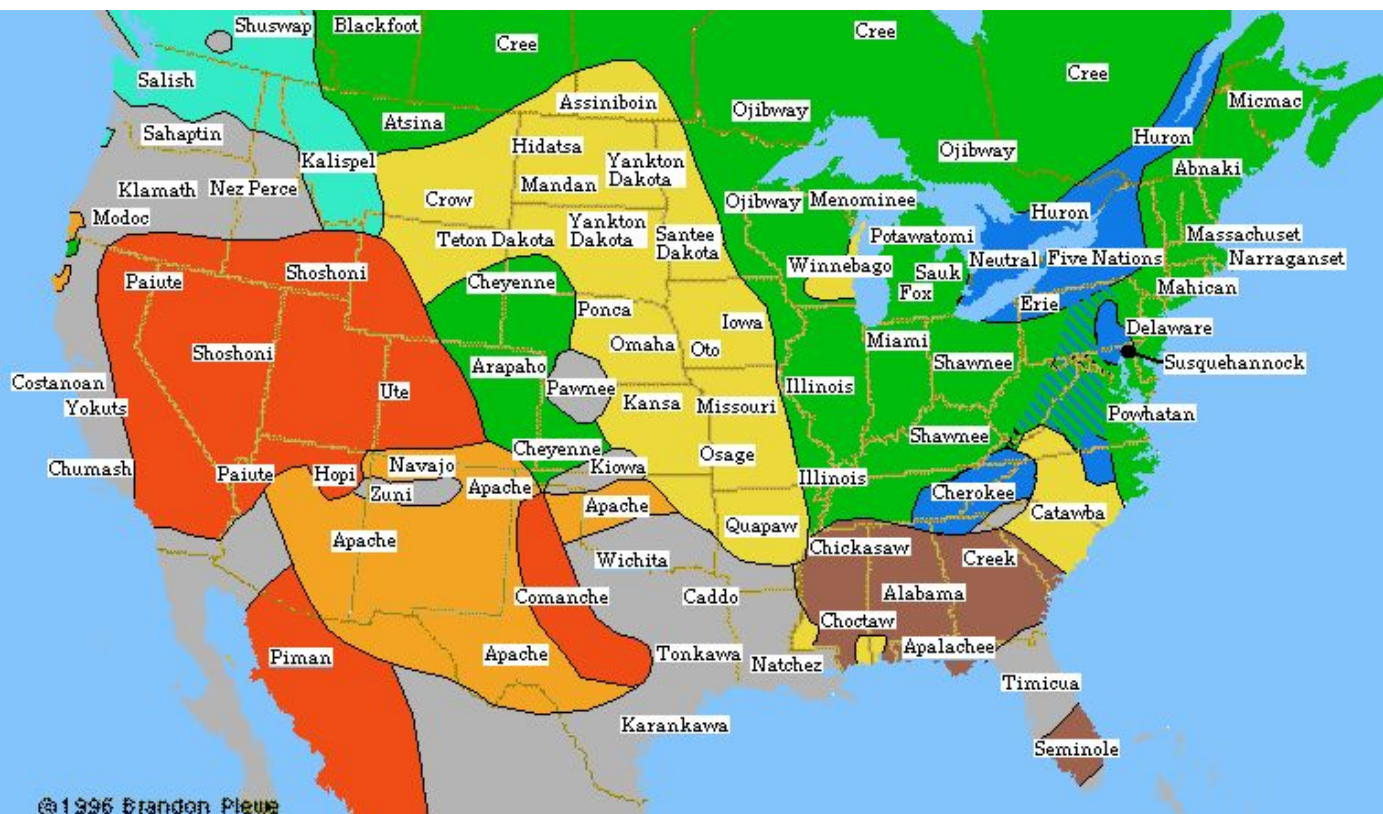




# Native Languages of North America

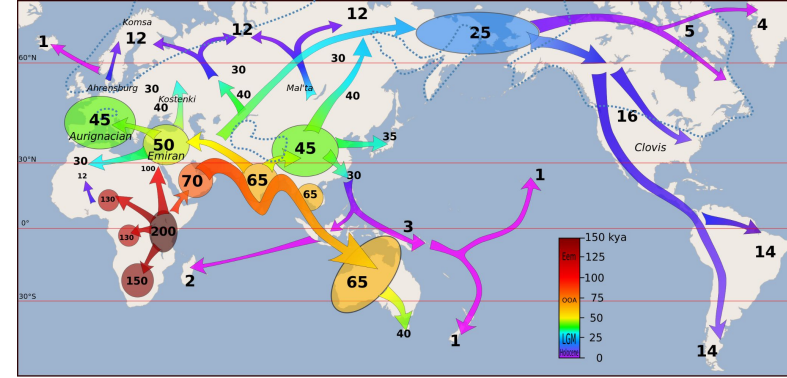
## Key to Language Families

- Algonquian
- Iroquoian
- Muskogean
- Siouan
- Uto-Aztecan
- Athabaskan
- Salishan
- Eskimo-Aleut
- Mayan
- all others



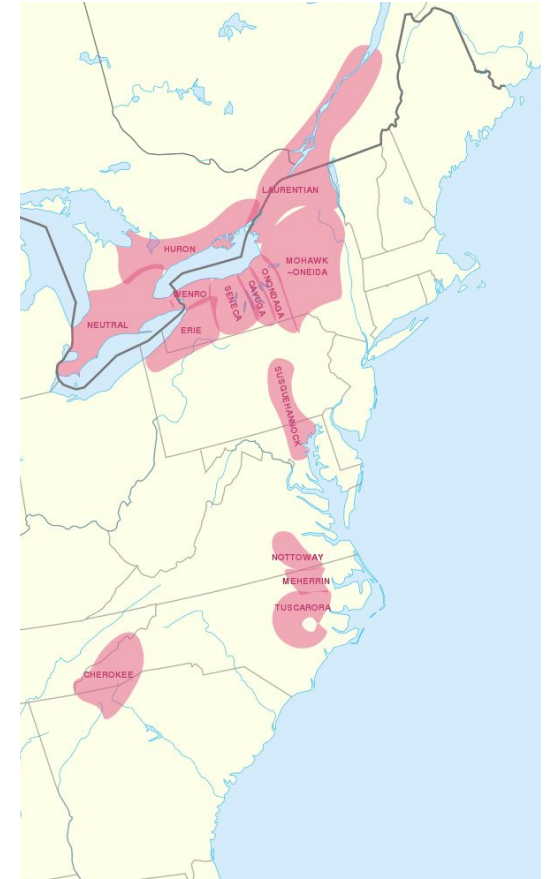
# Settlement of the Americas

- migration from Asia ~20,000 years ago, when the Beringia land bridge formed
- links to Siberian populations via linguistic and genetic factors
- conflicting theories of history of American languages:
  - single vs. multiple migrations, monolingualism vs. multilingualism
  - refuted “Amerind” hypothesis by Joseph Greenberg
- rapid settlement of North and South America by ~14,000 years ago





Algic (includes Algonquian) language family



Iroquoian language family

## Algic (includes Algonquian)

- major language family (~30 languages) of North America, from Rockies to east coast
- hunting, fishing, and gathering practices, cultivated “three sisters” corn/bean/squash
- polysynthetic morphology and complex verb systems, notably the direct-inverse alignment
- Blackfoot, Cree, Ojibwe, Passamaquoddy, etc.



### *Nucemak*

|    |      |     |        |
|----|------|-----|--------|
| n- | ecum | -a  | -k     |
| 1  | kiss | DIR | 3.PROX |

“I kiss them.” (Passamaquoddy)

### *Nucemkuk*

|    |      |     |        |
|----|------|-----|--------|
| n- | ecum | -ku | -k     |
| 1  | kiss | INV | 3.PROX |

“They kiss me.” (Passamaquoddy)

the person hierarchy is:

2 > 1 > 3.PROX > 3.OBV

when is direct vs. inverse morphology used?



how does the direct-inverse alternation in Algonquian compare to better known phenomena such as the Indo-European active-passive alternation?





the Massachusett language (Algonquian) and its neighboring languages



## Eskimo-Aleut language family

## Eskimo-Aleut

- language family (~11 languages) in arctic and subarctic regions of North America
- fishing and hunting with high protein diet, face tattoos practices, use of dog sleds
- rich polysynthetic morphology with small root inventory, ergative alignment system
- Aleut, Yupik, Inuktitut, Kalaallisut, etc.



*Tusaatsiarunnanngittualuujunga*

|        |        |         |        |         |              |
|--------|--------|---------|--------|---------|--------------|
| tusaa- | -tsiaq | -junnaq | -nngit | -tualuu | -junga       |
| hear   | well   | able to | NEG    | very    | 1SG.PRES.IND |

“I cannot hear very well.” (Nunavut Inuktitut)

*Angyaghllangyugtuqlu*

|         |        |         |      |         |      |
|---------|--------|---------|------|---------|------|
| angyagh | -ghlla | -nge    | -yug | -tuq    | -lu  |
| boat    | big    | acquire | want | 3SG.IND | also |

“Also, he wants to acquire a big boat.” (Central Siberian Yupik)

what is the ordering  
of morphemes in  
these languages?



is the distinction  
between a “word”  
and a “sentence”  
applicable in these  
languages?



Siouan language family

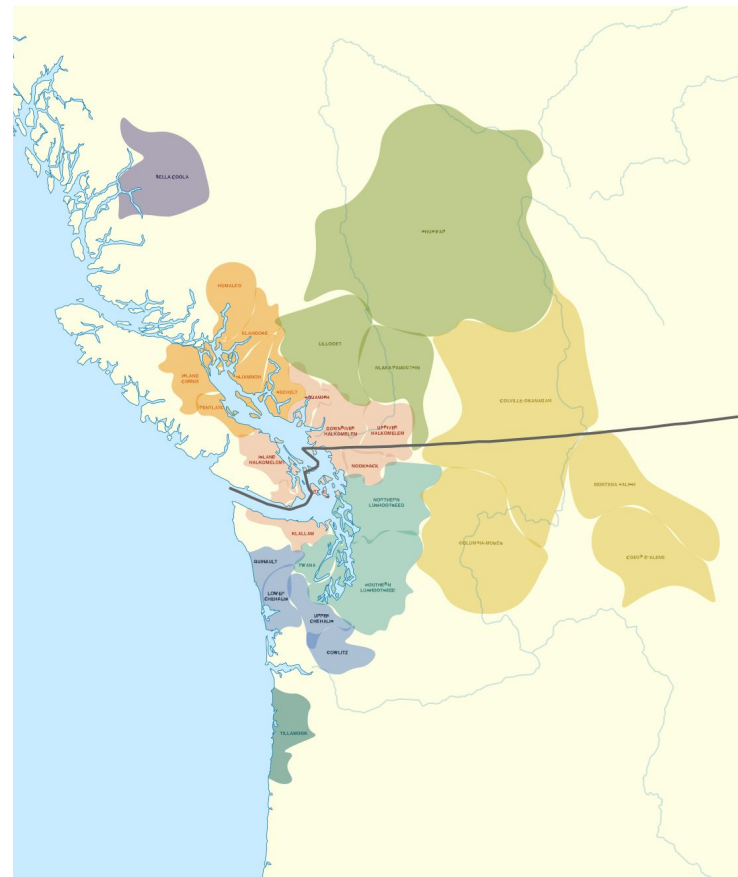


Muskogean language family





## Na-Dene (includes Athabaskan) language family



## Salishan language family

## Na-Dene (includes Athabaskan)

- major language family (~40 languages) in the northwest region and parts of the south
- small nomadic groups, fishing, hunting, and trapping practices, matrilineal system
- complex phonological systems with large consonant inventory and phonemic tone
- Tlingit, Eyak, Hupa, Navajo etc.



Proto-Athabaskan (PA) did not have phonemic tone

|        | Gwich'in | Tsuut'ina | Navajo     | Slavey      | Kaska | Hare          | Mattole | Galice | Dena'ina | PA                |
|--------|----------|-----------|------------|-------------|-------|---------------|---------|--------|----------|-------------------|
| "head" | -kìʔ     | -tsìʔ     | -tsì:ʔ     | -tʰíʔ       | -tsíʔ | -f(ʷ)íʔ       | -tsiʔ   | -siʔ   | -tsi     | *-tsiʔ            |
| "fish" | ɬúg      | ɬúk'á     | ɬóʔ ~ -lóʔ | ɬùè ~ -lùéʔ | ɬùgè  | lùgè ~ -lúgéʔ | ɬo-k'e  | ɬo-k'e | ɬiq'a    | *ɬu-q'ə ~ *ɬu-q'e |

“low tone marked”

“high tone marked”

“unmarked”

tonogenesis (the development of tone in language) happened in daughter branches independently due to effects of final glottalization

# Salishan

- language family (~20 languages) concentrated in Salish Sea area of the Pacific northwest
- weaving practices with plant/animal fibers, use of cedar for canoes and longhouses
- agglutinative morphology, large obstruent inventory with strings of syllabic consonants
- Bella Coola, Tillamook, Squamish, etc.



|           |           | Labial             | Alveolar           |                     |                     | Velar              |                                                                                                                   | Uvular             |                                             | Glottal |
|-----------|-----------|--------------------|--------------------|---------------------|---------------------|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------|
|           |           |                    | plain              | sibilant            | lateral             | palatal            | labialized                                                                                                        | plain              | labialized                                  |         |
| Stop      | aspirated | p <sup>h</sup> <p> | t <sup>h</sup> <t> | ts <sup>h</sup> <c> | tɬ <sup>h</sup> <ɬ> | c <sup>h</sup> <k> | k <sup>wh</sup> <k <sup>w<td>q<sup>h</sup> &lt;q&gt;</td><td>q<sup>wh</sup> &lt;q<sup>w<td></td></sup></td></sup> | q <sup>h</sup> <q> | q <sup>wh</sup> <q <sup>w<td></td></sup>    |         |
|           | ejective  | p' <p̰>            | t' <t̰>            | ts' <c̰>            | tɬ' <ɬ̰>            | c' <k̰>            | k <sup>w'</sup> <k <sup>w</sup> ̰>                                                                                | q' <q̰>            | q <sup>w'</sup> <q <sup>w</sup> ̰>          | ʔ       |
| Fricative |           |                    |                    | s                   | ɬ <ɬ>               | ç <x>              | x <sup>w</sup>                                                                                                    | χ <x̣>             | χ <sup>w</sup> <x̣ <sup>w<td>(h)</td></sup> | (h)     |
| Sonorant  |           | m                  | n                  |                     | l                   | j <y>              | w                                                                                                                 |                    |                                             |         |



is the distinction  
between a “vowel”  
and a “consonant”  
applicable in these  
languages?

*Clhp'xwlhtlhplhhskwts'* [xɬp'χ<sup>w</sup>ɬt<sup>h</sup>ɬp<sup>h</sup>ɬ:sk<sup>wh</sup>ts']

|         |                     |       |           |     |                    |
|---------|---------------------|-------|-----------|-----|--------------------|
| xɬ-     | p'χ <sup>w</sup> ɬ- | ɬp-   | ɬ-        | s=  | k <sup>w</sup> ts' |
| possess | bunchberry          | plant | PAST.PERF | 3SG | then               |

“Then he had had in his possession a bunchberry plant.” (Nuxalk)





# Mayan

- a major language family (~30 languages) in the Yucatan Peninsula of Central America
- known for architecture, hieroglyphic writing, art, and complex astronomical systems
- numeral classifier system, split ergative alignment, large obstruent inventory
- Ch'ol, K'iche', Kaqchikel, Mam, etc.



|     |        |        |      |     |
|-----|--------|--------|------|-----|
| lx- | ach-   | ko-    | chel | -a' |
| PFV | 2SG(B) | 1PL(A) | hug  | TR  |

“We hugged you.” (Chuj)

|      |        |        |        |      |
|------|--------|--------|--------|------|
| lan  | hach-  | ko-    | chelan | -i   |
| PROG | 2SG(B) | 1PL(A) | hug    | INTR |

“We’re hugging you.” (Chuj)

|     |        |      |      |
|-----|--------|------|------|
| lx- | ach-   | b’ey | -i   |
| PFV | 2SG(B) | walk | INTR |

“You walked.” (Chuj)

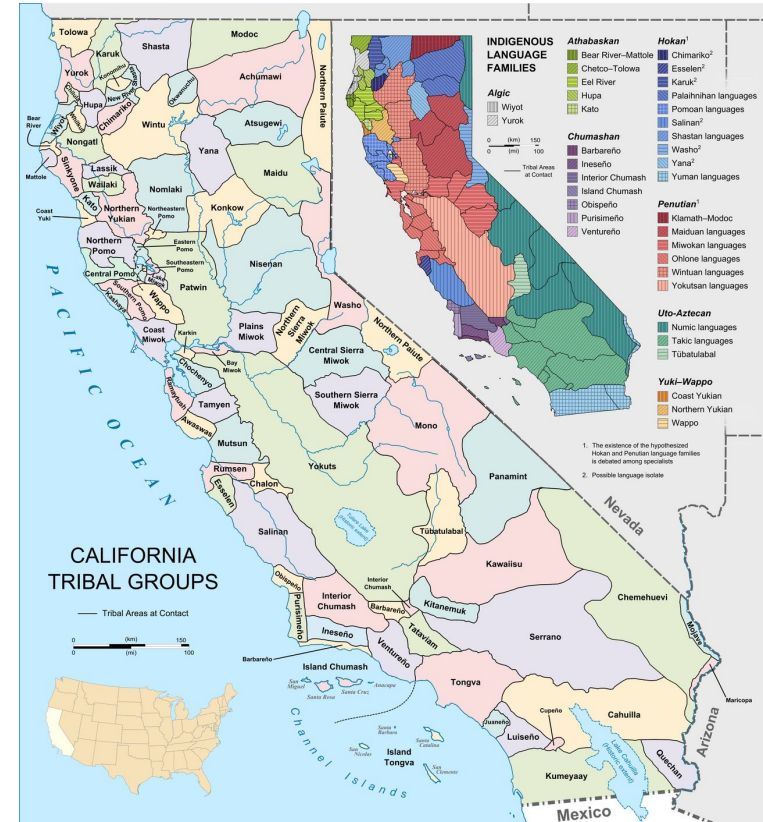
|      |        |      |      |
|------|--------|------|------|
| lan  | ko-    | b’ey | -i   |
| PROG | 1PL(A) | walk | INTR |

“We’re walking.” (Chuj)

how does aspect (perfective vs. progressive) affect the nominal alignment?

# areas of diversity

- notable areas of linguistic diversity:
  - California (~80 languages)
  - southeast woodlands
- potential factors:
  - coastal area and fertile land
  - warm climate
  - mountainous terrain



What is  
decolonization,  
and what are  
decolonial  
methods?







## **Leonard 2017:** **Producing language reclamation by decolonising ‘language’**

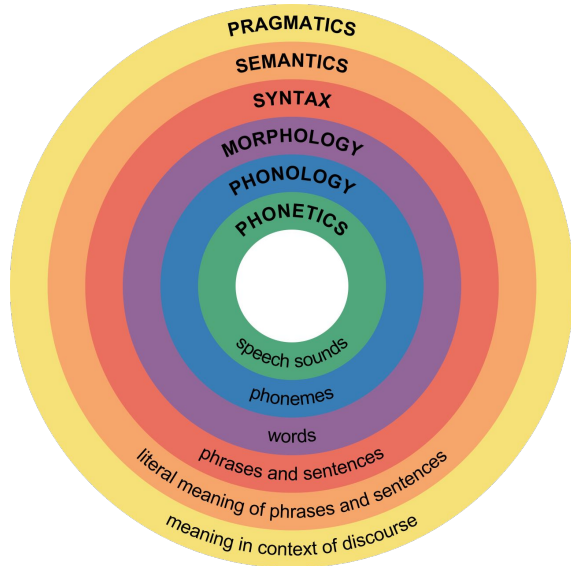
“I argue for a paradigm of *language reclamation*, which moves beyond a focus on direct language measures such as creating new speakers (*language revitalisation*), to incorporate community epistemologies such as how ‘language’ is defined and given sociocultural meaning” – page 15

## Decolonization

- prioritizing community goals and collaboration
- sensitive to colonial legacies and structures that affect worldview and perceived usefulness
- erasure of binaries: good vs bad, linguist vs. community member, expert vs. novice, etc.
- integrates “non-linguistic” factors into language, respects the local notions of language



a community can have diverse needs / wants, and differing opinions on and interest in language reclamation



## Role of a linguist and/or outsider

- NOT to produce information around linguistics units, but culturally appropriate units
- NOT to theorize on language as an object
- good intentions can have problematic effects:
  - create tension within the community
  - create resources that are disconnected from their cultural context and meaning
  - implicitly introduce standardization

## Revising the metrics

- what is a “good/fluent” speaker?
- is it productive to introduce norms and ideals of language assessment?
- alternatives:
  - focus on why language is important: shared sense of identity, how a community connects with each other and expresses their culture
  - address the underlying causes of language shift



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# Syllabus





# Logistics

- syllabus on Canvas
- class meeting dates: 3/19, 3/26, 4/2, 4/9, 4/16, 4/23
- post weekly comments on reading on Canvas discussion board
  - **\*\*\*no comments necessary for weeks 3 and 6\*\*\***
- two assignments: presentation (4/2), debate + reflection (4/23)